

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

The two brightest stars in the entire sky, Sirius in Canis Major and Canopus in Carina, blaze high in the sky for southern observers this month. Orion's brightest members, Rigel and Betelgeuse, are also high up, and Aldebaran, the brightest star in Taurus, glistens a ruddy color lower in the north. Closer still to the northern horizon, Capella is best placed for observation on January evenings. The rich Milky Way star fields of Carina and Centaurus lie in the southeast. By comparison, the western half of the sky appears almost barren, as it contains only a scattering of stars that are easily visible to the naked eye, the most prominent being 1st-magnitude Achernar, in the southwest at the end of Eridanus.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

The Orion Nebula is ideally placed for all southern observers this month because it is high in

ORION NEBULA

M41 is visible to the naked eye as a hazy patch of light, but its full complexity and beauty are brought out only in long-exposure photographs and CCD images.

the sky. M41, a large star cluster near Sirius, sits on the zenith for observers around 20°S. Under good conditions, M41 is just visible to the naked eye.

The Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) in Dorado looks like a detached scrap of the Milky Way lying on the meridian (an imaginary line passing north to south through the zenith) on January evenings. Prominent among its mass of stars is the Tarantula Nebula, which appears to the naked eye as a glowing patch as large as a full moon. The Small Magellanic Cloud (see p.311) in Tucana lies closer to the southwestern horizon.



URANUS



ORION'S BELT

A chain of three stars forms Orion's belt, south of which can be seen the nebulosity of M42. North is to the top of this picture.

NEPTUNE

